NUTRITION FUNDAMENTALS

The Science of Fueling Transformation

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NUTRITION COACH

Table of Contents

Part 1: The Science

Chapter 1: Energy Balance - The First Law

Chapter 2: Macronutrients - The Building Blocks

Chapter 3: Micronutrients - The Invisible Foundation

Chapter 4: Digestion & Absorption - The Delivery System

Part 2: The Strategy

Chapter 5: Calculating Your Nutritional Needs

Chapter 6: Meal Timing & Frequency

Chapter 7: Food Quality vs Quantity

Chapter 8: Supplementation - Evidence-Based Approach

Part 3: The Execution

Chapter 9: Building Your Meal Plan

Chapter 10: Tracking & Adjustment

Chapter 11: Social Situations & Flexibility Chapter 12: Troubleshooting Common Issues

Part 4: The Long Game

Chapter 13: Metabolic Adaptation

Chapter 14: Diet Breaks & Refeeds

Chapter 15: Transitioning to Maintenance

Chapter 16: Sustainability Framework

Introduction: The Nutrition Paradox

Part 1: The Science

Chapter 1: Energy Balance - The First Law

The Energy Balance Equation

Energy In - Energy Out = Change in Body Energy Stores

If Energy In = Energy Out → Weight maintenance

Historical Evidence: The Minnesota Starvation Experiment

Components of Energy Expenditure

2. Thermic Effect of Food (TEF) - 10% of TDEE

Why Most Diets Fail: The NEAT Trap

Chapter 2: Macronutrients - The Building Blocks

1. Muscle Protein Synthesis (MPS)

3. Thermic Effect of Food (TEF)

4. Muscle Preservation During Fat Loss

1. Amino Acid Profile

Chapter 3: Carbohydrates - Fuel, Not Enemy

Nutrition Fundamentals for Transformation

A Science-Based Framework for Sustainable Body

Composition Change

By Adriano | Transform Method

Table of Contents

PART 1: THE SCIENCE

CHAPTER 1: ENERGY BALANCE - THE FIRST LAW

CHAPTER 2: MACRONUTRIENTS - THE BUILDING BLOCKS

CHAPTER 3: MICRONUTRIENTS - THE INVISIBLE FOUNDATION

CHAPTER 4: DIGESTION & ABSORPTION - THE DELIVERY SYSTEM

PART 2: THE STRATEGY

CHAPTER 5: CALCULATING YOUR NUTRITIONAL NEEDS

CHAPTER 6: MEAL TIMING & FREQUENCY

CHAPTER 7: FOOD QUALITY VS QUANTITY

CHAPTER 8: SUPPLEMENTATION - EVIDENCE-BASED APPROACH

PART 3: THE EXECUTION

CHAPTER 9: BUILDING YOUR MEAL PLAN

CHAPTER 10: TRACKING & ADJUSTMENT

CHAPTER 11: SOCIAL SITUATIONS & FLEXIBILITY CHAPTER 12: TROUBLESHOOTING COMMON ISSUES

PART 4: THE LONG GAME

CHAPTER 13: METABOLIC ADAPTATION

CHAPTER 14: DIET BREAKS & REFEEDS

CHAPTER 15: TRANSITIONING TO MAINTENANCE

CHAPTER 16: SUSTAINABILITY FRAMEWORK

Introduction: The Nutrition Paradox

We live in the most information-rich era in human history. Yet obesity rates have tripled since 1975. In the United States, 42% of adults are obese. In Brazil, the rate has doubled in 20 years.

This is the nutrition paradox: more information, worse results.

Why?

Because the nutrition industry doesn't profit from simplicity. It profits from confusion.

One day fat is the enemy (low-fat era, 1980s-2000s)

Next day it's carbs (low-carb era, 2000s-2010s)

Then it's gluten (gluten-free trend, 2010s)

Then it's lectins (Plant Paradox, 2017)

Then it's seed oils (carnivore movement, 2020s)

Each trend creates a new market. New books. New supplements. New gurus.

But the fundamentals never change.

This guide is different. It's based on three principles:

1. Science over trends - What peer-reviewed research shows, not what sells supplements
2. Sustainability over perfection - What you can maintain for decades, not weeks
3. Results over ideology - What works for your body, not what works for a guru's brand

Let's begin.

PART 1: THE SCIENCE

CHAPTER 1: ENERGY BALANCE - THE FIRST LAW

Every diet that works does so because of one mechanism: energy balance.

This is not opinion. It's the First Law of Thermodynamics applied to human metabolism.

The Energy Balance Equation

Energy In - Energy Out = Change in Body Energy Stores

If Energy In > Energy Out → Weight gain (stored as fat or muscle)

If Energy In < Energy Out → Weight loss (from fat or muscle)

If Energy In = Energy Out → Weight maintenance

Historical Evidence: The Minnesota Starvation Experiment

In 1944, physiologist Ancel Keys recruited 36 conscientious objectors during World War II for a landmark study on starvation.

Protocol:

12-week baseline period (normal eating)

24-week semi-starvation period (50% caloric restriction)

12-week rehabilitation period (gradual refeeding)

Results: Average weight loss: 25% of body weight

Fat mass loss: 70% of total weight lost

Lean mass loss: 30% of total weight lost

Metabolic rate reduction: ~40% (adaptive thermogenesis)

Psychological effects:

Obsessive thoughts about food

Depression and irritability

Loss of libido

Social withdrawal

Key insight: You cannot outsmart thermodynamics. But you can optimize the process to preserve muscle, maintain hormones, and sustain adherence.

Components of Energy Expenditure

Your total daily energy expenditure (TDEE) consists of four components:

1. Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR) - 60-70% of TDEE

Energy required for basic physiological functions

Breathing, circulation, cell production, nutrient processing

Influenced by: body size, muscle mass, age, genetics

2. Thermic Effect of Food (TEF) - 10% of TDEE

Energy required to digest, absorb, and process nutrients

Varies by macronutrient: Protein: 20-30% of calories consumed

Carbs: 5-10% of calories consumed

Fat: 0-3% of calories consumed

1. Exercise Activity Thermogenesis (EAT) - 5-10% of TDEE

Energy expended during structured exercise

Highly variable (0% if sedentary, 30%+ if athlete) 4. Non-Exercise Activity Thermogenesis (NEAT) - 15-30% of TDEE

Energy expended in all activities outside of sleeping, eating, or sports-like exercise

Fidgeting, maintaining posture, occupational activities

Most variable component (can differ by 2,000 kcal/day between individuals)

Why Most Diets Fail: The NEAT Trap

When you reduce calories, your body adapts by reducing NEAT unconsciously:

You take the elevator instead of stairs

You sit more, stand less

You fidget less

You move slower

This adaptive reduction in NEAT can account for 200-500 kcal/day, effectively erasing your caloric deficit without you noticing.

Solution: Track steps daily (aim for 8,000-10,000) to maintain NEAT during fat loss.

CHAPTER 2: MACRONUTRIENTS - THE BUILDING BLOCKS

Macronutrients are nutrients your body needs in large amounts for energy and physiological function.

There are three macronutrients:

1. Protein
2. Carbohydrates
3. Fats

(Alcohol is technically a fourth macronutrient at 7 kcal/g, but it provides no nutritional value.)
Protein: The Transformation Macronutrient

Protein is composed of amino acids - the building blocks of muscle, enzymes, hormones, and neurotransmitters.

Why protein is non-negotiable for body transformation:

1. Muscle Protein Synthesis (MPS)

Protein provides amino acids for muscle repair and growth

Without adequate protein, you cannot build or maintain muscle

Muscle is metabolically active tissue (burns 6 kcal/kg/day at rest)

1. Satiety & Hunger Control

Protein is the most satiating macronutrient

Increases peptide YY (PYY) and glucagon-like peptide-1 (GLP-1) - satiety hormones

Reduces ghrelin - hunger hormone

Studies show protein reduces hunger by 60% compared to carbs or fats

3. Thermic Effect of Food (TEF)

20-30% of protein calories are burned during digestion

Example: 100g protein (400 kcal) → 80-120 kcal burned just processing it

This is why high-protein diets show slightly higher fat loss at equal calories

4. Muscle Preservation During Fat Loss

In a caloric deficit, your body breaks down tissue for energy

Adequate protein signals your body to preferentially burn fat, not muscle

Studies show 2.0-5.29g per pound (2.4g/kg) protein preserves 95%+ of muscle during fat loss

How Much Protein Do You Need?

The research consensus:

Goal Protein Intake Rationale

Sedentary 1.76g per pound (0.8g/kg) Minimum to prevent deficiency (RDA) adult

1.6-4.85g per pound Active adult Optimal for muscle maintenance & growth (2.2g/kg)

2.0-5.29g per pound Fat loss Preserves muscle, increases satiety (2.4g/kg)

1.6-4.85g per pound Muscle gain Higher end if natural, lower if enhanced (2.2g/kg)

1.2-3.53g per pound Prevents sarcopenia (age-related muscle Elderly (>65) (1.6g/kg) loss)

Example calculations:

176 lb (80kg) male, fat loss goal:

80kg × 2.2g = 176g protein/day

176g × 4 kcal/g = 704 kcal from protein

Spread across 4 meals = 44g per meal

132 lb (60kg) female, muscle gain goal:

60kg × 2.0g = 120g protein/day

120g × 4 kcal/g = 480 kcal from protein

Spread across 4 meals = 30g per meal

Protein Quality: Not All Proteins Are Equal

Protein quality is determined by two factors:

1. Amino Acid Profile

Essential amino acids (EAAs) - cannot be produced by the body

Leucine - the “anabolic trigger” for muscle protein synthesis

Complete proteins contain all 9 EAAs in adequate amounts 2. Digestibility

How well your body can break down and absorb the protein

Measured by DIAAS (Digestible Indispensable Amino Acid Score)

Protein quality rankings:

Source DIAAS Score Leucine per 100g Cost per 25g protein

Whey protein 1.09 11g $0.50

Egg whites 1.00 1.1g $1.20

Chicken breast 1.00 2.5g $1.00

Beef 0.98 2.5g $2.00

Salmon 0.95 2.0g $3.00

Tofu 0.82 1.0g $0.80

Lentils 0.63 0.7g $0.30

Peanut butter 0.46 0.6g $0.60

Key insight: Animal proteins are generally higher quality (complete amino acid profile, better digestibility). Plant proteins can work but require higher total intake and strategic combining.

Protein Timing: Does It Matter?

The “anabolic window” myth:

Old belief: Must consume protein within 30 minutes post-workout

Reality: The “window” is more like 4-6 hours

Total daily protein intake matters far more than timing

What actually matters:

1. Protein distribution

Spread protein evenly across meals (3-5 meals per day) Each meal should contain 30-50g protein

This maximizes muscle protein synthesis throughout the day

1. Pre-sleep protein

Casein protein before bed supports overnight muscle recovery

Studies show 30-40g casein pre-sleep increases muscle protein synthesis by 22%

1. Post-workout protein

Consuming protein within 2-3 hours post-workout optimizes recovery

Not critical, but beneficial if training fasted or early morning

CHAPTER 3: CARBOHYDRATES - FUEL, NOT ENEMY

Carbohydrates have been demonized for 20 years. It's time to set the record straight.

What Carbohydrates Actually Do

1. Primary fuel for high-intensity activity

Stored as glycogen in muscles and liver (~400-500g total)

Used preferentially during intense exercise (>70% max heart rate)

Cannot be replaced by fat for explosive movements

1. Protein-sparing effect

When carbs are adequate, protein is used for muscle building, not energy

In low-carb states, protein is converted to glucose (gluconeogenesis)

1. Hormone support

Insulin (anabolic hormone, drives nutrients into cells)

Leptin (satiety hormone, regulates metabolism)

Thyroid hormones (T3/T4, regulate metabolic rate)

Testosterone (anabolic hormone, muscle building) 4. Performance & cognition

Brain uses ~120g glucose per day

Low carbs impair cognitive function, mood, and decision-making

Athletes on low-carb diets show 5-10% performance reduction

The Low-Carb Trap

Yes, you'll lose weight fast on low-carb. But here's what's actually happening:

Week 1-2: Rapid weight loss (mostly water)

Glycogen stores depleted (1g glycogen binds 3g water)

Total water loss: 2-4kg

Fat loss: minimal

Week 3-4: Fat loss begins

Rate of fat loss identical to any caloric deficit

No metabolic advantage to low-carb at equal calories

Month 2-3: Adaptation or failure

Some people adapt well (genetic factors, activity level)

Most people experience: fatigue, irritability, reduced performance, poor adherence

The research verdict:

Meta-analysis of 32 studies (Hu et al., 2012):

Low-carb vs low-fat diets at equal calories → identical fat loss

Adherence was the only predictor of success

No metabolic advantage to either approach

Key insight: Low-carb works for some people because it helps them control calories. It's not magic. It's just another tool. How Much Carbs Do You Need?

It depends on your activity level:

Activity Level Carb Intake Rationale

2-6.61g per pound Minimum for brain function & Sedentary (3g/kg) hormones

Lightly active (1-3 3-8.82g per pound Supports moderate activity workouts/week) (4g/kg)

Moderately active (4-5 4-13.23g per pound Fuels training, optimizes workouts/week) (6g/kg) recovery

Highly active (6-7 6-17.64g per pound Maximizes performance & workouts/week) (8g/kg) recovery

8-22.05g per pound Athlete (2+ sessions/day) Prevents glycogen depletion (10g/kg)

Example calculations:

176 lb (80kg) male, training 5x/week:

80kg × 5g = 400g carbs/day

400g × 4 kcal/g = 1,600 kcal from carbs

132 lb (60kg) female, sedentary:

60kg × 2.5g = 150g carbs/day

150g × 4 kcal/g = 600 kcal from carbs

Carb Quality: Simple vs Complex

Simple carbs (fast-digesting):

Monosaccharides & disaccharides (glucose, fructose, sucrose)

Rapid blood sugar spike → insulin spike → potential energy crash

Best used: around workouts for quick energy

Complex carbs (slow-digesting): Polysaccharides (starches, fiber)

Gradual blood sugar rise → sustained energy → better satiety

Best used: majority of daily carb intake

Best carb sources:

Type	Examples	Fiber per 100g	Glycemic Index
Whole grains	Rice, oats, quinoa	2-4g	50-70
Starchy vegetables	Potatoes, sweet potatoes	2-3g	60-85
Legumes	Beans, lentils, chickpeas	7-10g	25-40
Fruits	Berries, apples, bananas	2-4g	30-60
Vegetables	Broccoli, spinach, peppers	2-3g	10-30

Carbs to minimize:

Refined sugars (candy, soda, pastries)

Processed grains (white bread, sugary cereals)

Not because they're "toxic," but because they provide poor satiety per calorie

CHAPTER 4: FATS - ESSENTIAL, NOT OPTIONAL

Dietary fat is the most misunderstood macronutrient.

Why Fat Is Essential

1. Hormone production

Cholesterol (from dietary fat) is the precursor to all steroid hormones: Testosterone

Estrogen

Cortisol

Aldosterone Chronically low fat (<1.10g per pound (0.5g/kg)) can suppress testosterone by 10-15%

1. Vitamin absorption

Vitamins A, D, E, K are fat-soluble

Without dietary fat, you cannot absorb these vitamins

Deficiencies lead to: poor immune function, weak bones, impaired vision

1. Cell membrane structure

Every cell in your body has a phospholipid bilayer (fat-based membrane)

Cell signaling, nutrient transport, and waste removal all depend on healthy membranes

1. Brain function

Your brain is ~60% fat by dry weight

Myelin sheaths (insulation for neurons) are made of fat

Omega-3 fatty acids (DHA) are critical for cognitive function

How Much Fat Do You Need?

Minimum: 1.10g per pound (0.5g/kg) body weight (to prevent deficiency) Optimal: 0.8-2.65g per pound (1.2g/kg) body weight (for health and performance)

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male:

Minimum: 40g fat/day (360 kcal)

Optimal: 64-96g fat/day (576-864 kcal)

132 lb (60kg) female:

Minimum: 30g fat/day (270 kcal)

Optimal: 48-72g fat/day (432-648 kcal) Fat Types: Not All Fats Are Equal

1. Saturated fats

Sources: Animal products (meat, dairy, eggs), coconut oil

Effect on health: Neutral to slightly positive (contrary to 1980s dogma)

Recommendation: 10-15% of total fat intake

1. Monounsaturated fats (MUFAs)

Sources: Olive oil, avocados, nuts

Effect on health: Positive (reduces LDL cholesterol, improves insulin sensitivity)

Recommendation: 50-60% of total fat intake

1. Polyunsaturated fats (PUFAs)

Sources: Fatty fish, flaxseeds, walnuts, sunflower oil

Two types: Omega-3 (anti-inflammatory): EPA, DHA, ALA

Omega-6 (pro-inflammatory in excess): Linoleic acid

Recommendation: 20-30% of total fat intake, prioritize omega-3

1. Trans fats

Sources: Partially hydrogenated oils, fried foods, processed baked goods

Effect on health: Strongly negative (increases LDL, decreases HDL, promotes inflammation)

Recommendation: Avoid completely

The Omega-3 to Omega-6 Ratio

Modern diets are heavily skewed toward omega-6 (from seed oils, processed foods).

Ideal ratio: 1:1 to 1:4 (omega-3 to omega-6) Modern ratio: 1:15 to 1:20

Consequences of imbalance:

Chronic inflammation Increased risk of cardiovascular disease

Impaired cognitive function

Solution:

Increase omega-3 intake (fatty fish 2-3x/week or supplement with 2-3g EPA/DHA daily)

Reduce omega-6 intake (limit seed oils, fried foods, processed snacks)

CHAPTER 5: MICRONUTRIENTS - THE INVISIBLE FOUNDATION

Micronutrients (vitamins and minerals) don't provide energy, but they're essential for:

Enzyme function

Immune system

Bone health

Energy production

Hormone synthesis

Most Common Deficiencies

1. Vitamin D

Function: Bone health, immune function, testosterone production

Deficiency symptoms: Fatigue, weak bones, frequent illness, low mood

Sources: Sunlight (15-30 min/day), fatty fish, fortified dairy

Supplementation: 2,000-4,000 IU/day if deficient

1. Magnesium

Function: Muscle contraction, nerve function, sleep quality

Deficiency symptoms: Cramps, poor sleep, anxiety, fatigue

Sources: Leafy greens, nuts, seeds, whole grains

Supplementation: 400mg/day (magnesium glycinate for best absorption) 3. Iron

Function: Oxygen transport (hemoglobin), energy production

Deficiency symptoms: Fatigue, weakness, pale skin, shortness of breath

Sources: Red meat, spinach, lentils, fortified cereals

Supplementation: Only if deficient (excess iron is toxic)

1. Zinc

Function: Immune function, testosterone production, wound healing

Deficiency symptoms: Frequent illness, low libido, poor recovery

Sources: Oysters, beef, pumpkin seeds, chickpeas

Supplementation: 15-30mg/day if deficient

1. Omega-3 (EPA/DHA)

Function: Brain health, anti-inflammation, cardiovascular health

Deficiency symptoms: Brain fog, joint pain, dry skin

Sources: Fatty fish (salmon, mackerel, sardines)

Supplementation: 2-3g/day if not eating fish 2-3x/week

Should You Take a Multivitamin?

Pros:

Insurance against deficiencies

Convenient

Low cost ($0.10-0.30/day)

Cons:

Most people don’t need it if eating varied diet

Some nutrients compete for absorption (iron vs calcium)

Quality varies widely between brands

Recommendation: If you eat a varied diet with vegetables, fruits, whole grains, and animal products → probably unnecessary

If you restrict food groups (vegan, carnivore, low-carb) → consider targeted supplementation

If you’re in a caloric deficit for fat loss → consider multivitamin as insurance

CHAPTER 6: DIGESTION & ABSORPTION - THE DELIVERY

System

You are not what you eat. You are what you absorb.

The Digestive Process

1. Mouth

Mechanical breakdown (chewing)

Salivary amylase begins carb digestion

1. Stomach

Gastric acid (pH 1.5-3.5) denatures proteins

Pepsin breaks down proteins into smaller peptides

Food becomes “chyme” (semi-liquid mass)

1. Small intestine (primary site of absorption)

Pancreatic enzymes break down macronutrients: Proteases → amino acids

Amylase → glucose

Lipase → fatty acids

Bile (from liver) emulsifies fats for absorption

Nutrients absorbed through intestinal villi into bloodstream

1. Large intestine (colon) Water and electrolyte absorption

Gut bacteria ferment fiber → short-chain fatty acids (SCFAs)

Formation of feces

Factors That Impair Digestion

1. Low stomach acid (hypochlorhydria)

Causes: Aging, stress, PPI medications (proton pump inhibitors)

Symptoms: Bloating, indigestion, nutrient deficiencies

Solution: Avoid PPIs unless medically necessary, consider betaine HCl supplement

1. Insufficient digestive enzymes

Causes: Pancreatic insufficiency, aging, chronic stress

Symptoms: Gas, bloating, undigested food in stool

Solution: Digestive enzyme supplement with meals

1. Gut dysbiosis (imbalanced gut bacteria)

Causes: Antibiotics, poor diet, chronic stress

Symptoms: Bloating, irregular bowel movements, food intolerances

Solution: Probiotic-rich foods (yogurt, kefir, sauerkraut) or probiotic supplement

1. Food intolerances

Common culprits: Lactose, gluten (in celiac disease), FODMAPs

Symptoms: Bloating, gas, diarrhea, abdominal pain

Solution: Elimination diet to identify triggers

Optimizing Digestion

1. Chew thoroughly

Aim for 20-30 chews per bite

Reduces burden on stomach and intestines

1. Don’t drink large amounts of water with meals

Dilutes stomach acid and digestive enzymes

Drink water 30 min before or after meals

1. Manage stress

Chronic stress reduces digestive enzyme production

Activates sympathetic nervous system (fight-or-flight), inhibits digestion

1. Include fiber

Feeds beneficial gut bacteria

Promotes regular bowel movements

Target: 30-40g fiber/day

1. Consider probiotics

Supports healthy gut microbiome

Especially beneficial after antibiotic use

Look for multi-strain formulas with 10+ billion CFUs

PART 2: THE STRATEGY

CHAPTER 7: CALCULATING YOUR NUTRITIONAL NEEDS

Now that you understand the fundamentals, let's build your personalized nutrition plan.

Step 1: Calculate Your Basal Metabolic Rate (BMR)

Use the Mifflin-St Jeor equation (most accurate for general population):

Men: BMR = (10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) - (5 × age) + 5 Women: BMR = (10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) - (5 × age) - 161

Example:

30-year-old male, 80kg, 180cm: BMR = (10 × 80) + (6.25 × 180) - (5 × 30) + 5 BMR = 800 + 1,125 - 150 + 5 BMR = 1,780 kcal/day

25-year-old female, 60kg, 165cm: BMR = (10 × 60) + (6.25 × 165) - (5 × 25) - 161 BMR = 600 + 1,031 - 125 - 161 BMR = 1,345 kcal/day

Step 2: Calculate Your Total Daily Energy Expenditure (TDEE)

Multiply your BMR by your activity factor:

Activity Level Multiplier Description

Sedentary 1.2 Little/no exercise, desk job

Lightly active 1.375 Light exercise 1-3 days/week

Moderately active 1.55 Moderate exercise 3-5 days/week

Very active 1.725 Hard exercise 6-7 days/week

Extremely active 1.9 Physical job + hard exercise daily

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male, training 4x/week (moderately active): TDEE = 1,780 × 1.55 = 2,759 kcal/day

132 lb (60kg) female, training 3x/week (lightly active): TDEE = 1,345 × 1.375 = 1,849 kcal/day

Step 3: Set Your Goal & Adjust Calories

Fat loss:

TDEE - 500 kcal = ~0.5kg loss per week (sustainable)

TDEE - 750 kcal = ~0.75kg loss per week (aggressive)

TDEE - 1,000 kcal = ~1kg loss per week (maximum, short-term only) Muscle gain:

TDEE + 300 kcal = ~0.25kg gain per week (lean bulk)

TDEE + 500 kcal = ~0.5kg gain per week (traditional bulk)

Maintenance:

TDEE = maintain current weight

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male, fat loss goal: Target calories = 2,759 - 500 = 2,259 kcal/day

132 lb (60kg) female, muscle gain goal: Target calories = 1,849 + 300 = 2,149 kcal/day

Step 4: Set Your Macros

Protein (set first, non-negotiable):

Fat loss: 2.0-5.29g per pound (2.4g/kg)

Muscle gain: 1.6-4.85g per pound (2.2g/kg)

Maintenance: 1.6-4.41g per pound (2.0g/kg)

Fat (set second, minimum for health):

0.8-2.65g per pound (1.2g/kg) body weight

Prioritize this range for hormone health

Carbs (set last, fills remaining calories):

Whatever's left after protein and fat

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male, fat loss, 2,259 kcal/day:

Protein:

80kg × 2.2g = 176g

176g × 4 kcal/g = 704 kcal

Fat: 80kg × 1.0g = 80g

80g × 9 kcal/g = 720 kcal

Carbs:

Remaining calories = 2,259 - 704 - 720 = 835 kcal

835 kcal ÷ 4 kcal/g = 209g

Final macros:

2,259 kcal

176g protein (31%)

209g carbs (37%)

80g fat (32%)

CHAPTER 8: MEAL TIMING & FREQUENCY

Does Meal Timing Matter?

For 95% of people: Total daily intake matters far more than timing.

But if you want to optimize:

Protein timing:

Distribute evenly across meals (3-5 meals with 30-50g each)

Maximizes muscle protein synthesis throughout the day

Post-workout protein within 2-3 hours (not critical, but beneficial)

Carb timing:

Prioritize carbs around training (before/after workouts)

Supports performance and recovery

Lower carbs in evening if you struggle with sleep (carbs can increase serotonin → drowsiness for some people)

Fat timing: No specific timing needed

Some people prefer lower fat pre-workout (easier digestion)

Meal Frequency: 3, 5, or 6 Meals?

The research:

No metabolic advantage to eating 6 meals vs 3 meals at equal calories

“Eating frequently boosts metabolism” is a myth

Meal frequency should be based on personal preference and adherence

3 meals/day:

Pros: Simpler, fewer decisions, larger meals (more satisfying)

Cons: Harder to hit high protein targets, longer gaps between meals

4-5 meals/day:

Pros: Easier to hit protein targets, stable energy, better for muscle building

Cons: More planning, more meal prep

6+ meals/day:

Pros: Constant energy, never hungry

Cons: Time-consuming, impractical for most people, no additional benefit

Recommendation: 4 meals/day for most people (breakfast, lunch, snack, dinner)

Intermittent Fasting: Does It Work?

What it is:

Time-restricted eating (e.g., 16-hour fast, 8-hour eating window)

Popularized by Martin Berkhan (Leangains), Dr. Jason Fung

Does it work for fat loss?

Yes, but only because it helps you control calories

No metabolic advantage over traditional eating at equal calories Works well for people who prefer larger meals and skip breakfast naturally

Downsides:

Harder to hit high protein targets (compressing meals into shorter window)

May reduce performance if training fasted

Can trigger binge eating in some people

Recommendation: Use IF if it helps you adhere to your calorie target. Otherwise, don’t force it.

CHAPTER 9: FOOD QUALITY VS QUANTITY

The IIFYM (If It Fits Your Macros) Debate

The claim: “As long as you hit your macros, food quality doesn’t matter. You can eat Pop-Tarts and lose fat.”

The truth:

For pure fat loss, this is technically correct (energy balance is king)

For health, performance, satiety, and sustainability, food quality matters

Why food quality matters:

1. Micronutrient density

200 kcal of broccoli ≠ 200 kcal of candy (vitamins, minerals, fiber)

1. Satiety per calorie

200 kcal of chicken breast (very filling) ≠ 200 kcal of cookies (not filling)

1. Thermic effect of food

Whole foods require more energy to digest than processed foods

1. Gut health

Fiber from whole foods feeds beneficial gut bacteria

Processed foods promote dysbiosis

1. Long-term health

Whole foods reduce risk of chronic disease (heart disease, diabetes, cancer)

Processed foods increase risk

The 80/20 Framework

80% of your diet: Whole, minimally processed foods

Lean proteins (chicken, fish, eggs, lean beef)

Whole grains (rice, oats, quinoa, bread)

Fruits and vegetables

Healthy fats (olive oil, avocados, nuts)

20% of your diet: Whatever you want (within your calorie budget)

Desserts, treats, social meals

Prevents feelings of deprivation

Improves adherence

Example weekly breakdown:

21 meals per week

17 meals (80%) = planned, whole foods, hitting macros

4 meals (20%) = flexible, enjoyable, social

CHAPTER 10: SUPPLEMENTATION - EVIDENCE-BASED APPROACH

The supplement industry is worth $140 billion globally. Most of it is unnecessary.

Here's what actually works: Tier 1: Proven, Worth the Money

1. Protein powder

What it does: Convenient way to hit protein targets

Dosage: 1-2 scoops/day (25-50g protein)

Cost: $0.50-1.00 per serving

Best type: Whey isolate (fast-digesting), casein (slow-digesting for pre-sleep)

1. Creatine monohydrate

What it does: Increases muscle strength, power, and size; improves cognition

Dosage: 5g/day (no loading phase needed)

Cost: $0.10 per serving

Evidence: 500+ studies, most researched supplement in history

3. Vitamin D

What it does: Supports bone health, immune function, testosterone production

Dosage: 2,000-4,000 IU/day (or 10-30 min sun exposure daily)

Cost: $0.05 per serving

Evidence: 50%+ of population is deficient

1. Omega-3 (EPA/DHA)

What it does: Reduces inflammation, supports brain health, improves cardiovascular health

Dosage: 2-3g/day (combined EPA + DHA)

Cost: $0.30 per serving

Evidence: Strong for cardiovascular and cognitive benefits

Tier 2: Helpful for Some People

1. Caffeine

What it does: Improves performance, focus, fat oxidation

Dosage: 200-400mg pre-workout (3-6mg/kg body weight) Cost: $0.10 per serving

Caution: Can disrupt sleep if taken within 6 hours of bedtime

1. Magnesium

What it does: Improves sleep quality, reduces muscle cramps, supports recovery

Dosage: 400mg before bed (magnesium glycinate for best absorption)

Cost: $0.15 per serving

Evidence: Beneficial if deficient (common in athletes)

1. Citrulline malate

What it does: Increases nitric oxide production, improves blood flow, reduces fatigue

Dosage: 6-8g pre-workout

Cost: $0.30 per serving

Evidence: Moderate evidence for endurance and pump

Tier 3: Save Your Money

Fat burners

Most contain caffeine (which works) + useless ingredients

Better to just take caffeine alone

BCAAs (branched-chain amino acids)

Unnecessary if you eat adequate protein

Whey protein already contains BCAAs

Testosterone boosters

None work unless you’re deficient in a specific nutrient (zinc, vitamin D)

If you’re deficient, just supplement that nutrient directly

Detox teas/cleanses

Your liver and kidneys already detox your body

No supplement can “cleanse” you

Collagen supplements

Weak evidence for skin/joint health

Better to just eat adequate protein (your body makes collagen from amino acids)

PART 3: THE EXECUTION

CHAPTER 11: BUILDING YOUR MEAL PLAN

Let's put everything together into a practical meal plan.

Example 1: 80kg Male, Fat Loss, 2,259 kcal/day

Macros:

176g protein

209g carbs

80g fat

Meal 1 (Breakfast - 7:00 AM):

3 whole eggs (18g protein, 15g fat)

2 slices whole wheat toast (8g protein, 30g carbs)

1 banana (1g protein, 27g carbs)

Total: 27g protein, 57g carbs, 15g fat (459 kcal)

Meal 2 (Lunch - 12:00 PM):

150g chicken breast (45g protein)

200g white rice (cooked) (4g protein, 56g carbs)

100g broccoli (3g protein, 7g carbs)

1 tbsp olive oil (14g fat) Total: 52g protein, 63g carbs, 14g fat (578 kcal)

Meal 3 (Pre-Workout Snack - 4:00 PM):

1 scoop whey protein (25g protein)

1 apple (21g carbs)

1 tbsp peanut butter (4g protein, 8g fat)

Total: 29g protein, 21g carbs, 8g fat (276 kcal)

Meal 4 (Dinner - 8:00 PM):

180g salmon (40g protein, 18g fat)

250g sweet potato (3g protein, 52g carbs)

150g mixed vegetables (3g protein, 10g carbs)

1 tbsp olive oil (14g fat)

Total: 46g protein, 62g carbs, 32g fat (722 kcal)

Snack (Optional - 10:00 PM):

200g Greek yogurt (20g protein, 6g carbs, 11g fat)

Total: 20g protein, 6g carbs, 11g fat (206 kcal)

Daily Total:

174g protein (close to 176g target)

209g carbs (exact target)

80g fat (exact target)

2,241 kcal (close to 2,259 target)

Example 2: 60kg Female, Muscle Gain, 2,149 kcal/day

Macros:

120g protein

240g carbs

65g fat Meal 1 (Breakfast - 8:00 AM):

100g oats (13g protein, 58g carbs, 7g fat)

1 scoop whey protein (25g protein)

1 banana (27g carbs)

1 tbsp almond butter (3g protein, 8g fat)

Total: 41g protein, 85g carbs, 15g fat (617 kcal)

Meal 2 (Lunch - 1:00 PM):

120g chicken breast (36g protein)

150g white rice (cooked) (3g protein, 42g carbs)

100g mixed vegetables (2g protein, 8g carbs)

1 tbsp olive oil (14g fat)

Total: 41g protein, 50g carbs, 14g fat (494 kcal)

Meal 3 (Pre-Workout Snack - 5:00 PM):

1 rice cake (1g protein, 15g carbs)

1 tbsp peanut butter (4g protein, 8g fat)

1 apple (21g carbs)

Total: 5g protein, 36g carbs, 8g fat (228 kcal)

Meal 4 (Post-Workout Dinner - 8:00 PM):

150g lean beef (39g protein, 15g fat)

200g sweet potato (2g protein, 46g carbs)

100g spinach (3g protein, 4g carbs)

1 tbsp olive oil (14g fat)

Total: 44g protein, 50g carbs, 29g fat (638 kcal)

Snack (Before Bed - 10:30 PM):

150g Greek yogurt (15g protein, 5g carbs, 8g fat)

30g granola (3g protein, 14g carbs, 5g fat)

Total: 18g protein, 19g carbs, 13g fat (257 kcal) Daily Total:

149g protein (above 120g target - good for muscle gain)

240g carbs (exact target)

79g fat (slightly above 65g target, but within acceptable range)

2,234 kcal (close to 2,149 target)

CHAPTER 12: TRACKING & ADJUSTMENT

Should You Track Macros?

Pros:

Ensures you’re hitting targets

Teaches you portion sizes

Removes guesswork

Cons:

Time-consuming

Can become obsessive for some people

Not necessary for everyone

Recommendation:

Track for 4-8 weeks to learn portion sizes

Then transition to intuitive eating (if you can maintain results)

Return to tracking if progress stalls

How to Track Accurately

1. Use a food scale

Measuring cups are inaccurate (especially for calorie-dense foods like nuts, oils)

Weigh everything in grams for first 2-4 weeks 2. Track everything

Cooking oils, sauces, condiments, “bites” all count

A tablespoon of olive oil = 120 kcal (easy to miss)

1. Use a tracking app

MyFitnessPal, Cronometer, MacroFactor

Scan barcodes for packaged foods

Create custom recipes for meals you eat frequently

1. Be consistent with timing

Weigh yourself same time each day (preferably morning, after bathroom, before eating)

Track weekly average (daily weight fluctuates 1-2kg due to water, food, waste)

When to Adjust

Fat loss plateau (no weight loss for 2-3 weeks):

Option 1: Reduce calories by 100-200 kcal/day

Option 2: Increase activity (add 2,000 steps/day or 1 extra workout/week)

Option 3: Take a diet break (eat at maintenance for 1-2 weeks, then resume deficit)

Muscle gain plateau (no strength or size gains for 4-6 weeks):

Option 1: Increase calories by 100-200 kcal/day

Option 2: Increase training volume (add 1-2 sets per muscle group per week)

Option 3: Deload week (reduce training volume by 50% for recovery) Chapter 13: Social Situations & Flexibility

The Restaurant Problem

Strategy 1: Plan ahead

Check menu online before going

Choose grilled protein + vegetables + starch

Ask for sauces/dressings on the side

Strategy 2: Estimate and move on

Don’t stress about perfect tracking

Estimate as best you can (most restaurants over-use oil/butter)

Get back on track next meal

Strategy 3: Bank calories

Eat 100-200 fewer calories earlier in the day

Use those calories for the restaurant meal

The Social Pressure Problem

“Why aren’t you eating dessert?”

“I’m full, but it looks great!”

“I’m saving room for later”

“I’m not hungry right now”

“You’re being too strict”

“I’m just being intentional about my goals”

“I feel better when I eat this way”

“I’ll have some next time”

“One bite won’t hurt”

“You’re right, but I’m good for now” “I appreciate it, but I’m satisfied”

Key principle: You don’t owe anyone an explanation for your choices.

The Alcohol Problem

Alcohol contains 7 kcal/g (almost as much as fat at 9 kcal/g).

Effects on body composition:

Inhibits muscle protein synthesis (reduces recovery)

Increases fat storage (alcohol is prioritized for metabolism, other nutrients stored as fat)

Reduces testosterone temporarily

Impairs sleep quality (disrupts REM sleep)

If you choose to drink:

Limit to 1-2 drinks

Choose lower-calorie options (vodka soda, light beer, dry wine)

Account for calories in your daily budget

Prioritize protein that day (to minimize muscle loss)

Hydrate (1 glass of water per drink)

Recommendation: Minimize alcohol during active fat loss or muscle gain phases. Save it for maintenance or special occasions.

PART 4: THE LONG GAME

CHAPTER 14: METABOLIC ADAPTATION

When you diet, your body adapts to conserve energy. Components of Metabolic Adaptation

1. Reduced BMR (10-15%)

Your body becomes more efficient (burns fewer calories at rest)

Partly due to weight loss (smaller body = lower BMR)

Partly due to adaptive thermogenesis (hormonal changes)

1. Reduced NEAT (15-30%)

You move less unconsciously (take elevator vs stairs, sit more, fidget less)

Can account for 200-500 kcal/day reduction

1. Reduced TEF (5-10%)

Less food = less energy spent digesting

1. Reduced EAT (10-20%)

Lower energy levels = reduced training intensity/volume

Total metabolic adaptation: 30-50% reduction in energy expenditure

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male:

Starting TDEE: 2,800 kcal/day

After 12 weeks of dieting (now 75kg): Expected TDEE (based on weight loss): 2,650 kcal/day

Actual TDEE (with adaptation): 2,200 kcal/day

Metabolic adaptation: 450 kcal/day

How to Minimize Metabolic Adaptation

1. Prioritize protein (2.0-5.29g per pound (2.4g/kg))

Preserves muscle mass (muscle is metabolically active)

1. Maintain training volume Don’t reduce weights or sets (signals body to keep muscle)

2. Track steps (8,000-10,000/day)

Prevents unconscious reduction in NEAT

1. Take diet breaks

Every 8-12 weeks, eat at maintenance for 1-2 weeks

Restores leptin, thyroid hormones, reduces stress

1. Don’t diet too aggressively

500 kcal deficit (0.5kg/week) is sustainable

1,000 kcal deficit (1kg/week) causes more adaptation

CHAPTER 15: DIET BREAKS & REFEEDS

Diet Breaks

What it is:

1-2 weeks at maintenance calories (TDEE)

Macros adjusted to maintenance (higher carbs, moderate protein, moderate fat)

Why it works:

Restores leptin (satiety hormone, suppressed during dieting)

Restores thyroid hormones (T3/T4, regulate metabolism)

Reduces cortisol (stress hormone, elevated during dieting)

Psychological break (reduces diet fatigue)

When to use:

After 8-12 weeks of continuous dieting

When fat loss plateaus despite adherence

When experiencing extreme hunger, fatigue, or mood issues

Example protocol:

10 weeks fat loss (500 kcal deficit)

2 weeks maintenance (TDEE)

Resume fat loss (500 kcal deficit)

Refeeds

What it is:

1-2 days per week at maintenance or slight surplus

Increase carbs significantly, reduce fat slightly, maintain protein

Why it works:

Temporarily boosts leptin (improves satiety and energy)

Replenishes muscle glycogen (improves training performance)

Psychological relief (breaks monotony of dieting)

When to use:

During extended fat loss phases (12+ weeks)

When training performance declines

When hunger becomes unmanageable

Example protocol:

Monday-Friday: 500 kcal deficit (2,259 kcal/day)

Saturday: Maintenance (2,759 kcal/day, high carb)

Sunday: Resume deficit

CHAPTER 16: TRANSITIONING TO MAINTENANCE

After reaching your goal, you need to transition to maintenance carefully. The Reverse Diet

What it is:

Gradually increasing calories from deficit to maintenance over 4-8 weeks

Add 100-200 kcal every 1-2 weeks

Why it works:

Allows metabolism to “catch up” (reduces adaptive thermogenesis)

Prevents rapid fat regain

Teaches you how to eat at maintenance

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male, finished fat loss at 2,259 kcal/day:

Week 1-2: 2,259 kcal/day (deficit)

Week 3-4: 2,400 kcal/day (+141 kcal)

Week 5-6: 2,550 kcal/day (+150 kcal)

Week 7-8: 2,700 kcal/day (+150 kcal)

Week 9+: 2,759 kcal/day (maintenance)

Maintenance Macros

Protein:

1.6-4.41g per pound (2.0g/kg) (slightly lower than fat loss, still prioritized)

Carbs:

Increase significantly (fuel performance, restore hormones)

Fat:

Moderate (0.8-2.65g per pound (1.2g/kg))

Example:

176 lb (80kg) male, maintenance at 2,759 kcal/day: Protein: 80kg × 1.8g = 144g (576 kcal)

Fat: 80kg × 1.0g = 80g (720 kcal)

Carbs: (2,759 - 576 - 720) ÷ 4 = 366g (1,463 kcal)

Final macros:

144g protein

366g carbs

80g fat

2,759 kcal

CHAPTER 17: SUSTAINABILITY FRAMEWORK

Transformation is not a 12-week program. It's a lifestyle.

The 3 Pillars of Sustainability

1. Enjoyment

If you hate your diet, you won't stick to it

Include foods you love (within your calorie budget)

Don't force yourself to eat foods you dislike just because they're "healthy"

1. Flexibility

Life happens (birthdays, holidays, travel)

Your nutrition plan must accommodate these events

Use the 80/20 rule (80% structured, 20% flexible)

1. Simplicity

Complex plans fail

Aim for 4-5 go-to meals you can repeat

Batch cook proteins and starches on weekends The Identity Shift

You don't need more willpower. You need a new identity.

Old identity:

"I'm trying to lose weight"

"I'm on a diet"

“I can’t eat that”

New identity:

“I’m someone who prioritizes my health”

“I’m an athlete in training”

“I choose not to eat that”

The difference:

“Trying” implies temporary

“I am” implies permanent

When your identity changes, your actions follow naturally.

Conclusion: The Long Game

Nutrition is simple. Not easy, but simple.

The fundamentals:

1. Energy balance determines weight change
2. Protein preserves muscle and controls hunger
3. Carbs fuel performance
4. Fats support hormones
5. Consistency beats perfection

The strategy:

1. Calculate your needs (BMR, TDEE, macros)
2. Build a meal plan you enjoy
3. Track for 4-8 weeks to learn portion sizes
4. Adjust based on results

The execution:

1. Prioritize protein at every meal
2. Include vegetables for micronutrients and fiber
3. Choose whole foods 80% of the time
4. Allow flexibility 20% of the time

The long game:

1. Take diet breaks every 8-12 weeks
2. Reverse diet into maintenance
3. Shift your identity
4. Build a sustainable lifestyle

You don’t need a perfect diet. You need a sustainable one.

Start with these fundamentals. Master them. Then optimize.

Because transformation isn’t built on perfection.

It’s built on repetition.

Ready to apply this?

Join the Transform Method and get:

Custom nutrition plan

Weekly 1-on-1 coaching

Private Discord community

Accountability system

Link in bio. References

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